The *real* Dad's Army

Featuring Bill Dixon and his son Jim

It was summer 1940. As Hitler's forces overran Europe, the dads who'd fought in the 1914-18 war rallied to defend Britain in the newly formed Local Defence Volunteers - soon to be called the Home Guard.

"Rally in Clifton Park. Father there with rifle. Mother and I as well"

On 14th May 1940 the Secretary of State for War Anthony Eden made a radio announcement calling on men aged 17 - 65 who were not in military service to enrol in the newly formed L.D.V. (Local Defence Volunteers) at their local police station. Within the first seven days 250,000 volunteers had attempted to join.

Jim wrote on **July 13:** 'Father came home in L.D.V. uniform.' The Clifton Park (Rotherham) rally took place the following day. On Churchill's orders, the L.D.V. was given the more inspiring title Home Guard on July 22. (Perhaps the fact people had nicknamed it 'Look-Duck-Vanish' had something to do with!)

Volunteers often became impatient about the delays in providing weapons and uniforms. The War Office issued instructions on the making of Molotov cocktails. (The episode of the sitcom Dad's Army in which a museum is plundered for antique weapons is apparently based on a real life incident.)

"Mother waited up for Dad, who caught a chill on L.D.V."

The above is Jim's diary entry for January 1 1941.

Jim turned 17 in November 1940 - old enough to join up. 'Joined and received uniform!' he recorded on **February 10 1941.**

February 11 1941
Went to H.G....did rifle drill ... Quite enjoyed myself. Life is going to be rather crowded.

February 16 (Sun) 1941
Up 9 and off to H.G. Route march to Grange Lane. ... My stride is too short.







Top left: Bill Dixon, Jim's father, in his Home Guard uniform; Top right: Bill in the First World War; Above: Bill at far right of front row - either war service or Territorial Army (Territorial Force until 1920), which I believe he joined before the First World War.

(Bill undertook fire-watching duties as well as Home Guard service - and still managed to run his Rotherham tailoring shop.)

Below is a cartoon from the 1945 book 'Home Guard Humour', reprinted by Amberly publishing.



"Live grenade throwing - persuaded them to let me have a try!"

Feb 18 1941
In the rookies' squad, sloping arms again. I'm still not much good!

Feb 21 1941
… up to H.G. Night duty. I was on a sweeping fatigue! It's a blinking nuisance.

April 13 1941
Manoeuvres and camouflage in Spring Wood. Good fun...

April 20 1941
Battalion manoeuvres. Acted as scout for rifle pit. Signalled approach of enemy. Helped to capture [illegible]. taken to Grange Wood to attack Keppel C. then captured (killed 1 enemy).

April 27 (Sun) 1941
...off to manoeuvres, despite rain, hail, snow. Captured HQ., although 'killed'. Sardine sandwiches, then back in lorry (25 of us!)

May 14 1941
Heard we were to have stretcher drill again, so went to H.G. Marched along Wortley Road in rain, then beer and lemonade to commemorate 1st anniversary of Home guard.

June 15 (Sun) 1941
Marched to Keppel's, [Keppel's column, an 18th century folly] then searched Scholes Coppice for '5th column', great fun.

June 16 1941
Very fine weather. Bomb-throwing - and sun-bathing.

June 18 1941
Moran kept drilling us all the b_____ time the _____ _____.

June 25 1941
... great fun stalking. Am to have service respirator on Friday.

June 28 1941
Denzil and others furiously envious of mask.

July 13 1941
Rifles issued - got rifle and bayonet!

July 21 1941
Live grenade throwing. … Persuaded them to let me have a try!



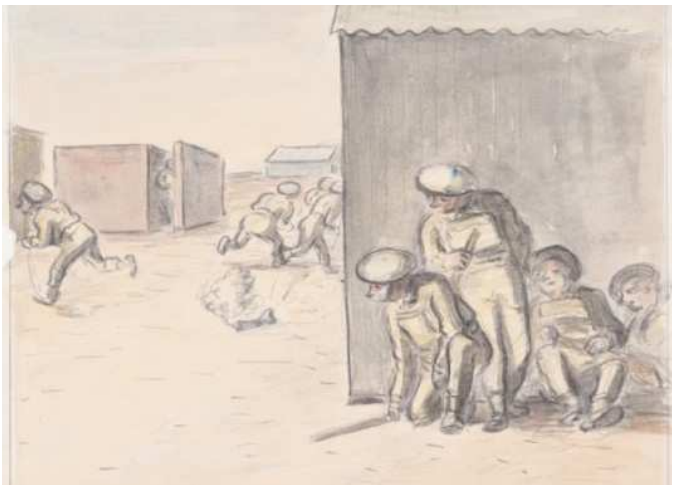
'Dad's Army' was a hugely popular BBC TV sitcom about Home Guard life that ran from 1968 to 1977. Teenage recruit Frank Pike (second from the right) resembles Jim in being a bored clerk alarmingly enthusiastic for his turn with the Tommy gun.

"were to have each fired the Tommy gun, but Ball stopped us - the rat"

July 23 1941
Rifle practice at Bradgate ... Still carrying remains of Mills bomb about.

August 9 1941
To work in uniform, boots and bayonet. Quite the centre of attraction.

August 18 1941
Definitely confirmed that Father is L/Cpl. He's quite pleased about it.



A Sunday morning with the Home Guard: the commandant lets off crackers (E. Ardizzone, 1941)

August 20 1941
Up to H.G. ... demonstration for American journalist.

Jan 18 1942
We went to the range at Jordan Pit, and were to have each fired the Tommy gun, but Ball stopped us – the rat. Likewise 'discipline is to be tightened up' – no doubt his idea. However, we had a lecture on the Blacker Bombard which was interesting. Another film show at the Premier, principally aircraft recognition…

March 12 1942
On duty, I cut my hands about a bit at Tommy gun drill...

March 22 (Sunday) 1942
Parade at 9.0 … we were to act as casualties in a test for the first aid people, which was rather a suck-in. I was a walking case – toddled down to Ferham House and was home by 11. Poor Dad was a stretcher case, was left lying in the cold for an hour or so!

June 15 1942
… H.G. parade at the Corpn. ARP [Air Raid Precaution] place at Mary St. We all went into the gas chamber to test our respirators. Afterwards some of them went in without their masks to 'smell the gas', and came out in a hurry! [Jim left for the regular army June 29]